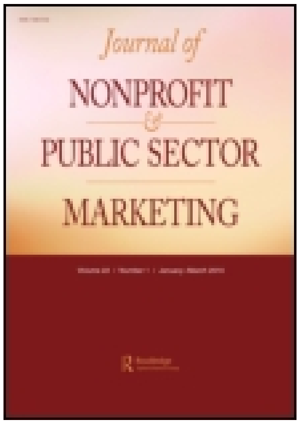

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The Concept of Brand Personality as an Instrument for Advanced Non-Profit Branding-An Empirical Analysis

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The Concept of Brand Personality as an Instrument for Advanced Non-Profit Branding– An Empirical Analysis

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ABSTRACT. In order to remain distinct and to build up strong relationships with their contributors in an increasingly competitive environment, an increasing number of non-profit marketers are attempting to exploit the profiling potentials of branding. For this reason, the paper addresses the use of the concept of brand personality for the brand management of NPOs. It reports on the development of a non-profit brand personality scale to assess the brand image of a non-profit organisation. Potential dimensions and items are drawn from relevant literature and from primary research. A number of research propositions are empirically tested, which present both a framework for theoretical discussion and practical implications for the non-profit sector. doi:10.1300/J054v19n01_04 *[Article copies available for a fee from The Haworth Document Delivery Service: 1-800-HAWORTH. E-mail address: <docdelivery@haworthpress.com> Website: <http://www.HaworthPress.com>*

KEYWORDS. Non-profit organisations, brand management, brand personality scale, factor analysis

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INTRODUCTION

Why does a liquorish-brown coloured carbonated drink sell billions of bottles each year? Why do a handful of daring environmental activists who cross a whaling ship's route in their rubber dinghy receive annual donations that easily exceed 100 million euro? (Greenpeace, 2004). The liquorish-brown coloured drink is Coke, which is currently, according to Interbrand, the most expensive brand in the world, with a market value of over 54 billion euros (Business Week, 2004). The environmental activists in their rubber dinghy are members of Greenpeace, the financially strongest ecology group in the world. Examples such as these show that non-profit organisations, like any large commercial enterprise, possess strong brands.

But whereas branding has long been an essential marketing tool of for-profit firms, driven primarily by the need to remain distinct and successful in an increasingly competitive environment, non-profits only began to discuss the strategic use of brands in their sector in the mid 1990s (Hankinson, 2001). Arguably, this development resulted from the severe competition non-profits began to face during the last decade: On the one hand substantial reductions in government funding exerted pressure on them to finance their operations from private donations (Webb et al., 2000). On the other hand an increasing number of non-profit organisations let competition for individual donations mount even higher. As a consequence, Greenpeace for example licensed its brand for products from different producers to increase income and popularity, and UNICEF recently undertook several activities related to branding in order to provide a well-defined image for their brand (Rusch, 2001; Rusch, 2002b).

However, despite such activities, it must be stated that most non-profits are still under-using their potentials for branding and that the use of brand-inherent profiling opportunities is often only a product of coincidence, as the charitable organisations do not consciously control this valuable asset (Tapp, 1996). In this sense, they fail, for example, to explore the specific traits and characteristics of their brands, the so-called brand personality, as key determinants as to why stakeholders choose to enter into a relationship with them and support their organisations.

This is not surprising, given the fact that research conducted in branding in general, and more specifically on brand personalities, has also mainly been based on for-profit brands. Additionally, in view of the rather more beneficial than economic nature of transactions in the non-profit sector, this research can and should not be applied to non-profits without major adaptations (Arnett et al., 2003; Hankinson, 2001; Ritchie et al., 1999).

Given the above illustrations, the objectives of our paper are twofold.

1. We aim to examine brand personalities in the non-profit sector in order to extend prior research on this prominent concept. Of key interest to our analysis here is what kind of brand personalities non-profits possess and how these can be measured. The purpose of this research is to present a brand personality scale that is directed towards the distinct characteristics of the non-profit sector.

2. We intend to provide a foundation for a more systematic use of branding strategies in the non-profit sector. Therefore we will analyse various non-profit brand personalities in order to assess their predictive validities on donors' likelihood to contribute. To achieve these goals our paper is organised as follows:

Section 2 defines the importance of non-profit branding as well as peculiarities of brand management in the non-profit sector. Section 3 then relates the existing research in the field of brand personality, in order to provide a comprehensive basis for its application to the brand policies of NPOs. In this connection, it becomes evident that concepts developed for the consumer goods market can be applied to the non-profit sector in general, but need further adaptations and extensions. Subsequently, the development of our extended brand personality scale for the non-profit sector is described and empirically tested for an exclusive set of NPOs (Section 4). We focus hereby on the German non-profit sector, as this market was until recently characterised by a much greater vicinity to the state than for example the US sector and therefore financially more secure. This fact lets us assume that the use and implementation of branding strategies differs even more clearly between for-profits and non-profits in Germany. We discuss the implications of our findings for both theory and non-profit marketers in Section 5.

BRAND MANAGEMENT IN THE NON-PROFIT SECTOR

Brand Management as a Strategic Tool in Competitive Markets

In markets in which competition is constantly intensifying, performance can naturally no longer differ greatly. This means, however, that brands gain increasing weight as warranties for performance (Kapferer, 2001). A brand is thereby defined as an associated perception, which is rooted in the psyche of the target group and retrieved through the display of symbols that represent the organisation. It both serves as a means of differentiation and functions as a platform for building meaning into relationships with the stakeholders of an organisation. This is due to the functions brands execute both for the brand owners and for their target groups (Hakinson, 2003).

In the eyes of a consumer, brands exert three major purposes: an information purpose, a risk-reduction purpose, and an image purpose. Brands facilitate orientation among and choice between certain products or services, and thus unburden the consumer. In their risk reduction function, brands serve as a signal and proof of quality. They serve as a safety measure, which elicits trust in the eye of the customer. Finally, it is becoming increasingly important for organisations to acknowledge the identity-creating effect of a brand. The identity-creating effect is the result of the projection of a brand's character onto the personality of the consumer, which then contributes to the creation of social prestige (Kapferer, 2001).

For the provider, brands also serve important purposes. Firstly, they improve the acquisition potential and have a positive effect on sales. Second, brands develop a positive stereotype in the minds of the customers, therefore creating a higher scope in price policy and protecting an enterprise from short-term crisis and heightened competition. Furthermore, strong brands also function as a basis to create new products and help to open up new markets containing new target groups (Kotler and Andreasen, 2003).

Importance and Peculiarities of Non-Profit Branding

Companies in the for-profit sector have had to fall back on the purely associative distinguishing characteristics of brands already several decades ago. With some time delay this development can now be observed in the non-profit sector. This is due to the fact, that in the meantime the number of competing organisations has substantially increased facing challenge on charitable organisations to attract and retain donors (Bendapudi et al., 1996). Furthermore, an expanding number of NPOs has noticed that a large part of the public no longer knows what interests it stands for or realises neither the goals nor the values of the organisation. As a consequence, more and more donors are becoming indifferent in their donor preferences. The weak emotional bond between the donor and the brand results in a low degree of brand loyalty. This weak bond is problematic, because it is much more expensive to acquire new donors than to maintain loyal ones. Given these trends, marketing techniques, such as market segmentation, relationship or database marketing, have been intensively applied to the non-profit sector during the last decade (for an overview see Venable et al., 2005). It is surprising however, that non-profit marketers still devote few activities to the development and strategic use of brands.

A first reason for this might lie in the fact that many non-profit practitioners think that their organisations are too complex for the differentiation function of a brand (Hakinson, 2000). This is because the non- profit brand lacks a direct affinity to products. It refers, instead, to the company itself in all its multi-layered complexity. It is thus not a tangible object; it does not possess any possibilities for physical differentiation. However, this "intangibility," the lack of direct physical encounters, does not prevent the development of a branding strategy (Ind, 1997). Such a discussion becomes irrelevant when one considers that a company, just as products and services, can be a reference unit for mental images.

The infrequent use of branding strategies in the non-profit sector is, however, due to a further fact: that is, the specific nature of transactions in the non-profit sector. In contrast to the typical monetary-based exchange in most for-profit transactions, "the act of giving to a non-profit organisation tends to be more social than economic in nature" (Venable et al., 2005, 297). This statement is supported by studies on charitable giving (Burnett and Wood, 1988), which show that the benefit for donors is mainly defined by a rise in *social* values. These range from personal satisfaction and approval to respect for humanitarianism (Arnett et al., 2003). However, as the term "branding" is still considered a commercial approach by many non-profits, they still regard its use as a betrayal of the ethical-social principals of the welfare sector (Saxton, 2002).

In this context we would like to point out that the manner in which a brand functions is not only independent on the object of reference, but also on the nature of the respective transaction that takes place. It solely differs in its different origin as well as type of value added to its stakeholders. In order to provide a better understanding for this point, we will have a closer look on transactions in the non-profit market.

Non-profits usually have two significant stakeholder groups. These are the contributors on the one hand and the beneficiaries on the other. Although there are cases in which these two groups overlap, the contributor usually–in contrast to classic for-profit transactions–only experiences the benefit of supporting an organisation *indirectly* via the benefit to the beneficiary, and thus perceives it–regardless of the type of organisation–as very similar; this is the aforementioned social benefit. As a consequence, NPOs have also intensified content-related differentiation difficulties, alongside the physical problems. Therewith however it becomes clear that the functions of brands described above are at least as important within non-profit transactions as in the for-profit sector, though partly of a different nature.

Brand Functions in the Non-Profit Sector

In the growing confusion of the Third Sector, the information function of non-profit brands–similarly to traditional product brands–provide reliable orientation. As an information focus, the brand's role is to create points of identification that structure and simplify the task of finding information for the stakeholder groups. It thus opens up a communication platform for non-profits, from which the values linked to the organisation are transported and relationships with contributors can be built up, controlled and maintained.

Moreover, the non-profit brand also serves to reduce risks for donors, although not in the sense of a traditional quality guarantee. As public trust in NPOs has constantly decreased because of various scandals, it should instead function as a seal of trust, which is capable of representing the organisation's transparency and integrity, as well as responsibility and reliability (Arnett et al., 2003; Morgan and Hunt, 1994). The ethical-social values of a non-profit brand may also have the effect of bestowing prestige. This helps donors to live out their own mental values with the brand or to transfer images associated with it to their own selves. In this sense, studies show that the congruence between the donor's values and the organisational values determines which organisation is supported (Bennett, 2003; Dolisch, 1969).

Overall, the illustrations show that non-profits–similarly to the quantity and price benefits in the profit sector–could create identification and differentiation characteristics in a competitive environment, intensify trust in their activities and thus secure their volume of donations by a strategic and targeted use of their brands. However, this also means that a large number of non-profit organisations have wasted considerable competitive advantages to date by not controlling the image of their brand in the public eye. In this context, Bendapudi (1996, 37) confirms, "that a charity's brand image may be the single most critical element of its promotional programme (. . .)."

Building up and maintaining a strong brand image, however, is a difficult task (Bernstein, 1985). In this context both research and practice have found the use of the "brand as person" metaphor to be an accepted device of building up successful brands in the for-profit sector (Davis and Chun, 2003). Therefore we too will introduce the history and further developments of this approach in marketing, and analyse whether it also presents a suitable instrument for an advanced non-profit branding.

THE CONCEPT OF BRAND PERSONALITY AS A DEVICE FOR AN ADVANCED BRAND POLICY IN THE NON-PROFIT SECTOR

History and Concept of Brand Personality

The concept of brand personality is based on the assumption that people tend to personify objects surrounding them. By describing brands in terms of human characteristics, it serves as a major device in generating brand attachment and brand awareness, in much the same way as people bond themselves together (Plummer, 1984). It is therefore seen as an enduring differentiation means in competitive markets (Tan Tsu Wee, 2003). Besides being able to differentiate brands, the personality factor might also reflect emotions or feelings of the brand, thus encouraging the target group to perceive the brand as an active, contributing friend and to enter into a long-term relationship with the brand (Aaker and Fournier, 1995).

The device of equating a brand with a person is not new: The realisation that people grant lifeless objects human qualities, even give them a soul, was already discussed in Gilmore's "Theory of Animism" at the beginning of the last century (Azoulay and Kapferer, 2003). Since then, the idea of brands having a personality just as human beings has been developed. It was practice that was thereby the first to coin the term "brand personality": As early as 1958, Martineau applied the expression to the characteristic dimensions of a retail store (Azoulay and Kapferer, 2003). Further studies followed, aiming to identify the personality factors that could contribute to a positive, strong brand image (cf. Lindquist, 1974; Berry, 1969).

Researching the concept of brand personality was initially seen as accessible only through qualitative rather than through quantitative data (Hanby, 1999; Durgee, 1988). The respondent is typically asked to imagine the brand as person and is questioned to suggest what type of car this person would drive or in what kind of house it would live, until a comprehending association is formed of the product or organisation (Davis and Chun, 2004; King, 1973).

As most of this work, however, was context-specific without providing any generic measurement approach to compare the consumer's perception of any company with that of its competitors (Markham, 1972), the quantitative measurement of brand personality was pursued from the beginning of the 1970s (Hieronimus, 2003). In this endeavour, researchers attempted to find human characteristics that completely describe a brand's personality. Much of this work was based on translated theories of human personality (for details see Azouley and Kapferer, 2003). Batra et al. (1993) for example used Anderson's (1968) human personality traits in order to measure the image of retail brands. As a result, seven factors entailing 35 items were defined. Comparably, Biel (1993) used 28 human descriptors to analyse brand image. In 1997, Aaker (1997) developed a measurement scale called the "Brand Personality Scale." In the development of her conceptual framework, she largely followed the steps of the US psychologists Costa and McCrae, who examined the famous "Big Five" or five-factor model (McCrae and Costa, 1989). She drew her scale thereby from a much larger list of possible items (114) than previous studies on brand management. To guarantee a universal solution, she explored 37 brands covering various industries. The end result of her study was a brand personality scale that consisted of 42 traits and 5 dimensions (see Table 1).

The final scale was tested and re-tested on large samples of American respondents. This follow-up research proved that Aaker's solution can be seen as a reliable and valid construct that analyses the perceived human characteristics of brands and measures the valence of these traits among subjects (Venable et al. 2005; Davies and Chun, 2003). Aaker's study has been directly replicated or variously adapted by many researchers (Davies and Chun, 2003; Aaker et al., 2001; Ferrandi et al., 2000; Koebel and Ladwein, 1999). As most recent work examining brand personalities is thus based on the "Brand Personality Scale," this measure can be seen as a milestone in the investigation of brand personality.

Transferability of the Aaker Scale to the Non-Profit Sector

Despite the comprehensive capabilities of Aaker's Brand Personality Scale described above, it can not simply be adopted for the purpose of our study, but needs some specific adaptations and extensions. This is due to some limitations of Aaker's work:

TABLE 1. The Brand Personality Scale of Jennifer L. Aaker

Sincerity	Excitement	Competence	Sophistication	Ruggedness
down-to-earth family-oriented small-town	**daring** trendy exciting	**reliable** hard working secure	**upper class** glamourous good looking	**outdoorsy** masculine Western
honest sincere real	**spirited** cool young	**intelligent** technical corporate	**charming** feminine smooth	**tough** rugged
cheerful sentimental friendly	**up-to-date** independent contemporary	**successful** leader confident		
wholesome original	**imaginative** unique			

Source: Authors' own illustration of the scale according to Aaker, J. (1997) .

As a first reason, the "Brand Personality Scale," which was developed and validated only in an US-American context, cannot be generalised in an intercultural context, making it unsuitable for transferring to the German non-profit market. In this sense, studies conducted in the French market (Ferrandi et al., 2000), in the Japanese and Spanish markets (Aaker et al., 2001) and in the German market (Hieronimus, 2003) indicate that the number of dimensions and their corresponding items vary by culture.

An even greater limitation for our purpose, however, lies in the fact that Aaker only analysed B2C brands and neglected the evaluation of both B2B and non-profit brands. To illustrate this better, we recall the fact that non-profit brands possess certain peculiarities that reveal important differences to the profit sector. In Section 2 we contended that, contrary to for-profit brands, brand management in the non-profit sector should emphasize the central values of both the organisation and its supporters. These values are the organisation's "heart and soul" and establish its right to exist, as they provide for the *social* benefits the stakeholder group of contributors is looking for. Brands in the non-profit sector are thus often attributed with traits such as trustworthiness, social competence, humanity, idealism, solidarity, etc. (Cermak et al., 1994). Few of these characteristics appear in Aaker's scale. It is possible that these traits were not considered relevant for brands of consumer goods and were therefore excluded in the process of item reduction. In either case, their absence allows us to assume that it is not advisable to transfer the "Brand Personality Scale" to the non-profit sector without adaptation. Our presumption is confirmed by the fact that attempts were recently made to remove this insufficiency and to grasp and measure the entireness of a non-profit brand personality.

In this context, Venable et al. (2003) and a follow-up study of this work by Venable et al. (2005) analysed brand perceptions in three US non-profit sectors (environment/rights, health, and arts/humanities) by using qualitative preliminary studies. In doing so, they found out that people could very easily characterise NPOs and their brands using personality traits. The terms the participants used were, on the one hand, similar to those used for for-profit brands. On the other hand, however, new descriptive words were discovered which were related to the thoughtfulness, integrity and reliability of NPOs. Based on these results, the scholars analysed the structure of brand personality using factor analysis. Additionally to the new descriptive items derived from their preliminary study, all items from the Aaker scale were used. The result was a four-factor scale. As shown in Table 2, two of Aaker's original five factors (sophistication and ruggedness) and two new factors (integrity and nurturance) were retained. A subsequent confirmatory factor analysis supported these four dimensions among US non-profit organisations.

The goal of an earlier study by Bennett and Gabriel was to measure the influence of brand personalities on consumers' decision to buy products of NPOs and, in relation, to evaluate the related potential for a transfer of a brand (Bennett and Gabriel, 2000). To operationalise the construct of brand personality, an item list was generated, which was based on several studies conducted in the sector of non-profit marketing and non-profit management. According to a resulting list of 26 items, 94 students evaluated two items of their choice from popular non-profit brands on a five-point scale. This resulted in 188 evaluations for each item. On this basis, a variety of explorative factor analyses were con-

TABLE 2. Factors and Items of the Venable et al. Scale

Integrity	Ruggedness	Sophistication	Nurturance
honest	tough	good-looking	compassionate
positive influence	masculine	upper-class	caring
committed to public good	outdoor	glamorous	loving
reputable	western		
reliable			

Source: Authors' own illustration of the scale according to Venable et al. (2005).

ducted with a different number of factors. The best result was found to be a four-factor solution that included 19 items as shown in Table 3.

Although both studies constitute important preparatory work for using the concept of brand personality in the non-profit sector, they are subject to certain limitations. The scale of Venable et al. was again examined in the US context only. Bennett and Gabriel's construct, in addition, was generated solely on the basis of items taken from the non-profit literature, and does not provide a theoretical background and context for the "Big Five" of the human personality, as well as the already discovered dimensions of brand personalities.

To come to a first conclusion, we must state that the understanding of brand personality in the non-profit sector is still not well developed: Regarding the US context, there are still only few studies which have tried to measure non-profit brand personality; concerning the German non-profit market, as a representative of a late mover market regarding branding activities, not a single study exists. The next chapter is dedicated to providing a partial solution to this deficit.

CONCEPTION OF A BRAND PERSONALITY SCALE FOR THE GERMAN NON-PROFIT SECTOR

Method and Objectives of This Research

Because prior research has not examined brand personality in a non-profit market characterised until recently by a relatively strong support of gov-

TABLE 3. Factors and Items of the Bennett/Gabriel Scale

Emotive altruism	Efficiency	Trust	Modernity
compassionate	well-managed	trustworthy	progressive
sympathetic	spends money on beneficiaries rather than admin	reliable	modern
kind	uses its assets wisely	honest	energetic
idealistic	highly professional	non-political	innovative
caring	employs people who really know how to get things done		
passionate			

Source: Authors' own illustration of the scale according to Bennett, R., Gabriel, H. (2000)

ernment funding, such as for example the German non-profit sector, we chose to use a multi-method design. Firstly, we applied a discovery approach that consisted of two qualitative methods: in-depth interviews of current non-profit professionals and content analysis of the mission statements of German non-profit organisations. After summarising the results of these studies, we conducted a third and a fourth study, in order to quantitatively investigate brand personalities in the non-profit sector. Altogether, our methodology was designed to address the following research questions:

1. What are the characteristic dimensions of German non-profit brand personalities and how can they be measured?
2. Do non-profit brand personalities influence charitable giving intentions?

Based on our aforementioned conclusions,

- that Aaker (1997) did not consider any non-profit brands in developing the "Brand Personality Scale,"
- that non-profit brands differ from consumer brands in that they have to emphasize the comprehensive, long-term values of a charitable organisation, and
- that donors seek social benefits when supporting a charitable organisation,

our specific research propositions were:

$P_{1:}$ Aaker's Brand Personality Scale is not able to describe brand personalities from the non-profit sector in their entirety and thus cannot be replicated in this context.

$P_{2a:}$ Contrary to for-profit brands, attributes based on social values present an important dimension of non-profit brand personalities. They are depicted by a discrete factor in an adapted non-profit brand personality scale.

$P_{2b:}$ The higher the attributes based on social values are rated for an organisation by an individual, the higher is the potential willingness to contribute to this organisation.

Qualitative Studies

As we were able to assume, on the basis of the previous theoretical considerations, that the items of the "Brand Personality Scale" are not sufficient for describing brand personalities in the non-profit sector satisfactorily, we conducted preliminary studies for item selection among non-profit practitioners (study 1). Moreover, mission statements of German NPOs were analysed (study 2).

Study 1. In the first qualitative study, we conducted in-depth interviews with marketing experts from eight of the largest German NPOs. In order to assure an adequate sample selection for the purpose of our study, we analysed the structure of the German non-profit market more in detail. According to the "International Classification of Non-profit Organisations" (ICNPO), the non-profit market consists of 12 sectors. According to Priller and Zimmer (2001) the relevant sectors of the German non-profit market are: culture/arts, education/science, health care, social services, environment, housing, consumer interests, foundations, international activities, and industrial unions.

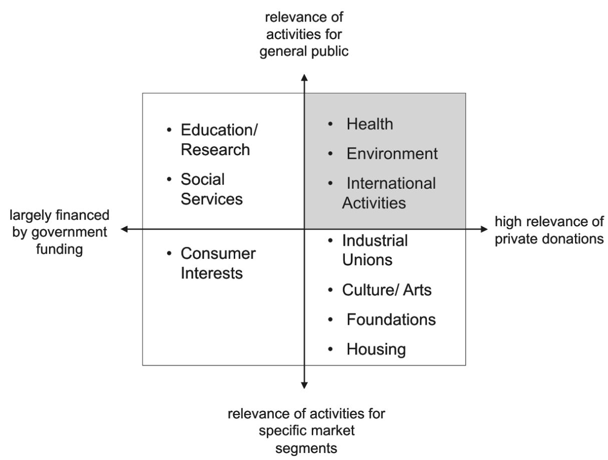
Although all sectors are non-commercial, they dispose of central differences. This heterogeneity becomes most evident when looking at two dimensions: This is their form of financing as well the relevance of their activities for the general public.

As illustrated in Figure 1, there is a clear dichotomy of the non-profit market: On the one hand, there are sectors that are still very closely linked with the state (arts/science, social services, consumer interests), which are almost exclusively financed by government funding. On the other hand, the remaining sectors are characterised by a much more segmented financing structure, which can be subdivided into both government support and private donations, however with a growing tendency towards the latter. As a consequence, these sectors clearly face a stronger competition for individual donations than the three previously mentioned sectors. It can be assumed that the provision of elaborated marketing techniques is also of higher relevance in these sectors. Therefore, we believed that it would best suit the purpose of our study to conduct expert interviews in NPOs from the right side of the illustration.

However, we did not include representatives from the lower right quadrant. This is due to the fact that German NPOs, besides their financing form, can also be distinguished by the degree to which their activities either address the general public or focus on specific market segments. Similarly to the previous classification, it can be assumed that brand relevance differs between these two categories and that branding importance will mount with increasing broad effect.

Following these considerations, we selected marketing experts from eight German NPOs as interviewees, whose organisations all were rep-

FIGURE 1. Structure of the German Nonprofit Market



Source: Authors' own illustration according to Priller, E., Zimmer, A. (2001)

resentatives of the upper right classification quadrant. An overview of our sample is depicted in Table 4.

All in-depth interviews were conducted by telephone and structured by guidelines containing the following questions: Firstly, the interviewees were asked to indicate the degree of competition their organisation faces as well the financing form by which their charity is mainly funded, in order to assess the validity of our accomplished classification scheme. We then asked the experts what characteristics they regarded as most suitable to describe their type of organisation. Here, we instructed the interviewees to list at least three adjectives that describe their charity "as if had come to life as a person."

Study 2. In addition to the in-depth interviews, images and "mission statements" from a further 22 well-known German NPOs were analysed by means of content analysis, in order to derive additional items for the questionnaire. This procedure seems to be particularly appropriate, as mission statements contain the inherent values und norms of an organisation by displaying the charity's goals and behavioural maxims. This time we did not restrict our analysis to the upper right quadrant of our classification scheme, in order to enhance the comprehensiveness of our qualitative research.

TABLE 4. In-Depth Interviews: Sample Selection

Health Care	Environment	International Activities
GRK (German Red Cross)	Greenpeace	Deutsche Welthungerhilfe
AOK	BUND (German Environmentalists)	Amnesty International
	WWF	SOS-Child Care

Results. Overall our qualitative work was able to extract 61 items found suitable to describe the brand personalities of NPOs. However, some of these terms were found to be similar to those used by consumer brands or were synonyms or antonyms of established characteristics. We therefore reduced the collection by 11 items. Consequently, we attained 50 new descriptive items during our qualitative phase (cp. also Table 5).

Quantitative Studies

We conducted the research in the quantitative phase in a two-step process: Firstly, we conducted a pilot study among faculty, staff and student donors in order to reduce our qualitatively generated item pool to the relevant items (study 3). Then, during the main survey (study 4), we examined our proposed research hypothesis by means of exploratory factor analysis.

Study 3. To finally reduce the item pool to relevant items, 50 survey participants were personally asked to evaluate four non-profit brands each according to the remaining 50 items. The average age of the participants was 34.7 years; 62% of the participants were male. For stimuli selection, we used the same non-profit classification scheme that we employed in the qualitative study. Analogous to the sample selection in our in-depth interviews, we selected only NPOs belonging to the upper right category, where the highest brand relevance could be identified. With the three organisations Greenpeace (environment), German Red Cross (health) and Unicef (international activities), we selected three NPOs that possess, according to the German fundraising community, both a very high degree of recognition and of fundraising revenue. In addition to these three organisations funded by donations, the AOK–the market leader among the statutory health insurance schemes–was also

TABLE 5. Calculation of Item Relevance

Relevant Items	mean-scors	Excluded Items	mean-scors
experienced	4.79	motivating	3.96
international	4.79	environmentalist	3.90
humane	4.76	open-minded	3.86
social	4.68	rational	3.85
professional	4.65	approachable	3.82
present	4.64	tolerant	3.82
responsible	4.53	selfless	3.81
non-commercial	4.52	modern	3.80
peaceful	4.43	optimistic	3.79
authentic	4.43	educative	3.79
independent	4.39	flexible	3.77
idealistic	4.37	computable	3.76
effective	4.30	creative	3.71
persevering	4.28	pluralistic	3.71
trustworthy	4.28	enthusiastic	3.69
adventurous	4.26	cooperative	3.69
just	4.23	entrepreneural	3.56
critical	4.22	innovative	3.51
courageous	4.21	transparent	3.36
careful	4.18	sparing	3.31
solidary	4.16	changeable	3.31
sympathetic	4.15	inspiring	3.27
neutral	4.08	radical	3.82
fostering	4.05	spiritual	2.69
fair	4.05	sportive	2.53

included. This appears practical, as the competition between the health insurers is still in an early phase but the battle for market shares is accelerating at speed. Although the statutory health insurers are financed by means of payments for services, they may be allocated to the non-profit market, as they are not permitted to make profits. In total, our four selected brands can be judged as representative of the brand-relevant part of the German non-profit sector.

In order to identify items which were considered as appropriate to define a non-profit brand personality, the mean value of all evaluations of each item was calculated, and a cut-off was used at "4 = applies somewhat." As a result, 25 items were rated as relevant and included in the main survey. These new descriptors as well as the excluded items are depicted in Table 5.

Study 4. The brand selection of the main study followed the previously conducted pilot study, in order to increase the reliability of our results. However, in order to be able to compare non-profit personality profiles with international profit brands, Coke and BMW, two of the most powerful brands in the commercial world, were additionally selected. In order to minimise respondent fatigue, each respondent was asked to only evaluate how descriptive the brand personality traits were for two of the NPOs and for one consumer brand. Therefore two versions of the questionnaire were available (cp. also Table 6).

The sampling frame of our main study included students, faculty and staff of three German universities (University Stuttgart-Hohenheim, University Duisburg and University Münster) as well as anonymous self-selected Internet users. This is due to the fact that we chose an online questionnaire as a survey methodology in our main study. This online questionnaire was publicised through links on the homepages of the three universities' marketing departments. To ensure high participation levels, the department chairs were asked to additionally inform their students, faculty and staff of the survey. During a period of four weeks, we received 249 usable replies to the online questionnaires. The aver-

TABLE 6. Overview of Usable Replies

Brand	Number of Replies	Questionnaire
AOK	134	1
UNICEF	134	1
GRK	115	2
Greenpeace	115	2
evaluations per item in the non-profit sector	**498**	
Coca-Cola	134	1
BMW	115	2
evaluations per item in the profit sector	**249**	

age age of the participants was 28.8 years, with a span ranging from 17 to 63 years. With a percentage of 60.6, male participants were slightly overrepresented. Approximately 50% of all participants were students, 29% were employees and 14% were either self-employed or in managerial positions. The distribution of replies across our two versions of the questionnaire is depicted in Table 6.

At the beginning of the online questionnaire we placed two qualifying questions. The first was to ensure that the respondents had been involved with one or more non-profits in the past 24 months. The other was to guarantee that the interviewees knew all the brands included in their respective questionnaire.

In the next section of the survey, the respondents were asked to evaluate the given brands based on 67 items. These items were the 42 items from the Aaker scale and the additional 25 items found to be relevant during the preliminary study. The evaluation of characteristics was again conducted with the aid of a six-point rating scale.

Test of Research Propositions

In order to test our first research proposition P_1, an exploratory factor analysis on the basis of the *original 42 items* was conducted to examine the extent to which our empirical data corresponded with the five-factor solution of the Aaker scale. The database consisted of all item evaluations for the four non-profit brands. This analysis resulted in a three-factor solution based on interpretation and a scree plot. By examining this result in detail, it became obvious that from the original five factors of the Aaker scale, the two dimensions Sincerity and Competence melt into one new dimension, and the same applies to the dimensions Excitement and Sophistication. In total, 11 items would have to be excluded as they either show too high cross-loadings or do not load on any factor higher than 0.5. These findings confirm that Aaker's scale is insufficient to describe brand personalities in the non-profit sector.

For the development of an extended scale for the non-profit sector (cf. research proposition P_{2a}), we conducted a further explorative factor analysis, this time including *all 67 items* of the questionnaire. In this analysis we also extracted a three-factor solution. In order to receive a stable factor structure, we thereby applied, additionally to the scree plot criterion, the demand that each factor should provide at least four item loadings of 0.6 or above. As it is a well-known fact that factor loadings vary by number of extracted factors, we also extracted, besides the three-factor solution, a four-factor and a five-factor solution. However, the aforementioned additional demand could not be accomplished. Only two items loaded on factor 4 higher than 0.6 and none at all loaded on factor 5. These factors are thus hardly interpretable. Consequently, we extracted the three-factor solution as final result.

Because in this solution, too, some items did not provide unambiguous loadings, we had to reduce the original item list to 42 items. Both items from the Aaker scale (22) as well items from our newly generated item pool (3) (these were present, idealistic and independent) had to be excluded thereby. The criteria for the item reduction were:

- Factor loading of at least 0.55 on one factor.
- Cross-loading not higher than 0.4 on the other factors.
- No loadings on more than one factor (for this demand, the difference between the highest loading of an item and the closest lower loading > 0.2).

Thus the generated three-factor solution could explain 60.42% of the total variance, which we can consider as satisfactory. Because of the broadness of the factors and in order to facilitate the factor interpretation, we conducted additional factor analysis for the item list of each of the three factors. Aaker applied the same procedure in order to determine her "facets" which are especially highlighted in Table 1. According to Aaker, these facets are representative enough to the dimension they load on, in other words they allow a more parsimonious description of brand personalities (Aaker, 1997). According to the Kaiser criterion, we can establish two such facets for each of the two larger factors, and one facet for the smallest factor.

The first of these factors consists of 23 items. It encompasses the majority of the items (17) addressing the discussed peculiarities of the non-profit market. It thus especially emphasizes social values, which were said to be of high relevance for NPOs. In addition, this factor includes 4 items from Aaker's Sincerity factor and 2 from the Competence factor. We will therefore call this factor Social Competence and Trust. The second factor contains the remaining 5 of our residual item list. Moreover, it contains 6 items from Aaker's Excitement factor as well as 2 items from the Ruggedness factor. We will call this second factor Emotion and Assertiveness. The third and smallest factor only consists of one facet. It unifies the remaining 4 characters of Aaker's Sophistication factor, and both one item of the Aaker factors Sincerity and Excitement. Because of the similarity regarding the content of this factor to the Aaker's Sophistication factor, we decided to name the third factor Sophistication and Exclusivity.

The three factors constitute an excellent interpretation of the factor structures, providing unambiguous and high loadings. We found out that all three of the symbolic personality dimensions demonstrate high reliability. In this sense, alpha coefficients of the three factors were 0.965 for "Social Competence and Trust," 0.935 for "Emotion and Assertiveness" and 0.848 for "Sophistication and Exclusivity." The adjusted item-to-total correlation provided a mean level of 0.71 and lies between 0.58 and 0.83. We therefore assume a high level of internal reliability for the factors.

The stability of this solution was tested with a variety of sample surveys, examining the structure of the factors (Aaker 1997). Explorative factor analyses were therefore conducted for six different groups of participants. The same items loaded on exactly the same factors and the measured loadings were of similar value. Although the stability of our solution was thus tested only by exploratory means, the exact replicability of the three factors in every sample survey substantiates our assumption of a stable solution. The brand personality scale for the non-profit sector is depicted in Table 7.

As a distinct factor representing the social values was extracted in our factor analysis and as this factor, moreover, is the largest factor of the newly generated scale, research proposition P_{2a} can be confirmed, allowing us to go on to test hypothesis $P_{2b.}$

However, before doing so, we want to compare the distinct personality profiles of non-profit brands with those of consumer brands, in order to provide one further illustration for the predominant position of the *social* dimension when analysing brand personalities in the non-profit sector. In this context, we examined the difference of item means of both sectors. The results of a t-test showed that 31 of the 42 item-means differ for non-profit and commercial brands at a significance level of 99.9%. These considerable differences become apparent in the personality profiles in Figure 2. Especially in the top and bottom parts showing the items of the factors described above, those profiles diverge dramatically. The profiles only intersect in the middle of the table, in the section of the factor Emotion and Assertiveness.

These results demonstrate once more: non-profit brands are graded as considerably more trustworthy and with a higher social competence than for-profit brands. This social dimension could not have been captured by applying scales from the profit sector.

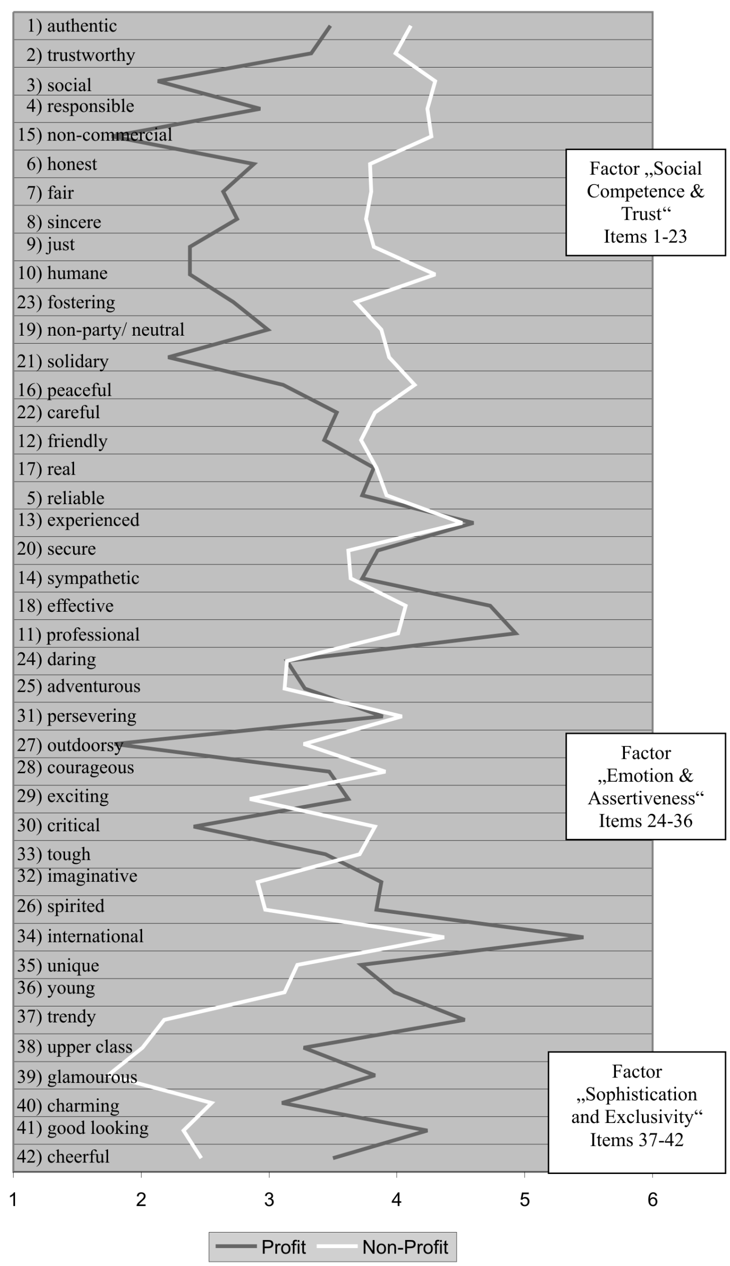
TABLE 7. Brand Personality Scale for the Non-Profit Sector

"Social Competence and Trust"	"Emotion and Assertiveness"	"Sophistication"
humane non-commercial just social sympathetic solidary fair fostering trustworthy honest sincere responsible authentic real non-party/ neutral peaceful	**spirited** exciting imaginative outdoorsy adventurous daring young unique	**charming** cheerful good looking glamourous trendy upper class
secure careful reliable effective experienced professional friendly	**persevering** tough courageous critical international	

Many studies have been conducted to examine the determinants of influence on donors. As already mentioned in Section 2 the results showed that the efficiency of the organisations and trust in their inherent values are key determinants (Bennet; Gabriel 2000). As these factors equal for the most part the factor Social Competence and Trust, we tested research proposition P_{2b} in the following way:

In our questionnaire, we also examined to which of the organisations (UNICEF, German Red Cross; Greenpeace) the participants would donate 100 euros if they had them at their disposal for donations. The decision to make a donation to one of the three organisations thereby does not imply that the donation actually has to take place, but it shows a higher affinity to one brand in comparison to the two others.

FIGURE 2. Brand Personality Profiles Profit/Non-Profit in Comparison



We then compared the factor values of the three organisations of the factor Social Competence and Trust. Indeed, the number of potential donors for an organisation increases positively in line with its factor value, as Greenpeace, with a factor value of 3.65, only has 40 potential donors, and with a value of 4.37 the GRK has 83 potential supporters. With a factor value of 4.45, UNICEF even has 126 potential donators.

However, to get a better understanding as to why people are willing to support an organisation, a comparison between potential donors and non-donors was conducted on the item level. For this purpose, a t-test was carried out between donors and non-donors. The goal was to filter out significant item-mean differences. The result shows a clear picture of the relevant factors of influence. Table 8 shows all the mean differences with a significant level of at least 99%. When looking at the items, it becomes evident that all items–except "charming"–belong to the factor "Social Competence and Trust." Therefore, the hypothesis P_{2b} can also be confirmed.

CONCLUSIONS AND OUTLOOK

Non-profit brand management is still at its starting point. Practice and research still devote few of their efforts towards branding activities. This is certainly due to the fact that there is a clear lack of both understanding of the special characteristics of non-profit brands and concepts that help to build up and maintain a strong brand image in the context of non-profit markets.

In this context, the adaptation of the concept of brand personality to the non-profit sector can be seen as a suitable and effective solution, as it serves as a valuable means of differentiation as well as platform of identification in an increasingly competitive non-profit sector. Therewith it also influences key targets of NPOs such as the individual's contribution behaviour. However, it is not advisable to adopt the concept of brand personality of consumer goods to the non-profit sector without adaptations, as brand personalities in the for-profit sector usually do not relate to attributes addressing the social values of their companies. In this sense our illustrations could prove that the structure of brand personalities in the non-profit sector differs significantly from the structure of consumer brands.

For this reason, the first purpose of our study was to develop a suitable measurement for non-profit brand personalities. Hereby, we focused on the German non-profit market, as no study has yet examined non-profit

TABLE 8. Significant Item-Mean Differences for Potential Donors

Organization	Item Name	T-Value	df	Sig. (2-sided)	Mean Difference
GRK	sympathetic	2.82	113	.006	.64
	honest	3.39	113	.001	.79
UNICEF	social	2.75	132	.007	.57
	effective	2.79	132	.006	.55
Greenpeace	fair	3.69	113	.000	.99
	sympathetic	5.04	113	.000	1.50
	professional	2.80	113	.006	.83
	trustworthy	3.08	113	.003	.91
	fostering	3.12	113	.002	.93
	authentic	4.20	113	.000	1.28
	real	3.21	113	.002	.90
	just	3.04	113	.003	.80
	honest	2.94	113	.004	.92
	responsible	3.07	113	.003	.96
	careful	3.22	113	.002	.86
	charming	2.86	113	.005	.77

brand personalities outside of the US context to our knowledge, where initial, though few research activities on non-profit brand personalities have been undertaken in recent years. Our purpose was confirmed by previous studies that reveal that most existing work examining brand personalities show a lack of intercultural generalisability and thus can hardly be replicated in other cultures. Regarding the of the growing internationalisation of non-profit activities, this deficient generalisability however indicates a clear starting point for further research to our mind. In this sense the long-term goal should be the development of a non-profit personality scale, which can be globally applied. A first starting point towards this goal could be the comparison and confirmatory validation of the scale developed by Venable et al. (2005) and our scale in an intercultural setting.

A second goal of our study was to give some implications for future advanced brand management in the non-profit sector. In this sense, our study reveals that non-profit marketers should define their self-perceived state precisely in the form of a mission statement. The target personality of the brand should be derived on this basis. In addition, the brand personality should be measured as to how it is perceived by the relevant target groups. In order to do so, the operationalised scale of this study can be used in markets resembling the German non-profit sector. Building on the results, a target-actual comparison regarding the target group and the actually perceived brand personality must be conducted. The most important question for this step is whether the current position is desirable and, if not, whether the target group can be reached at all with the available resources.

Due to the limitations of our study, we would like to mention some further fields of research that would improve the practical implication of the discussed concept. These are the provision of a better understanding of the influence of the different dimensions of a brand personality on key factors such as paying for non-profit products and services. Moreover, insights on brand affinity, brand confidence and brand identification of NPOs must also be gained.

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